

Session 28: Reflecting on Jonah 1

Key Takeaways

- God is dealing with horrific human evil, but he doesn't wave it away. He lets people sit in the mess they create, but not forever.
- Even our evil can become an instrument of God's purposes.

Deceptive Prophet, Fearful Pagans

Jonah's deception of the sailors—not telling them he was running from Yahweh—is discovered. And the irony of this is made clear by two hyperlinked design patterns that compare Jonah to Pharaoh in [Exodus 14](#) and then to Achan in [Joshua 7](#).

Jonah as Pharaoh

Pharaoh's Deception and the Israelites' Fear

Exodus 14:5 NASB*

When the king of Egypt was **told** (ויגד) that the people had **fled** (ברח), Pharaoh and his servants had a change of heart toward the people, and they said, **“What is this we have done** (עשינו זאת מה), that we have let Israel go from serving us?”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 14:10 NASB*

As Pharaoh drew near, the sons of Israel looked, and behold, the Egyptians were marching after them, and they became **very afraid** (מאד ויראו) and the sons of **Israel cried out** (ויצעקו) to the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah's Deception and the Sailor's Fear

Jonah 1:5 NASB*

And the sailors **were afraid** (וייראו) and they **cried out** (ויצעקו) each to his god ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 1:9 NASB*

I am a Hebrew, and I fear (ירא) Yahweh, the God of the heavens who made the sea and dry land.

Jonah 1:10 Instructor's Translation

And the men were **afraid, a very great fear** (וייראו...יראה גדולה) and they said, **"What is this you have done to us?!"** (מה זאת עשית), for the men knew that he had **fled** (ברח) from Yahweh, for he **told** (הגיד) them.

Note that in this analogy, Jonah has been paired with Pharaoh as the deceiver, while the sailors have been paired with the helpless Israelites who are at the mercy of the deceiver. The main difference is that Jonah has not premeditated his deception, whereas for Pharaoh, his actions are the culmination of a long series of deceptions.

Jonah as Achan

The Eden Deception in Genesis

Genesis 3:6 Instructor's Translation

And the woman saw that the tree was good (כי טוב העץ) ... and desirable (נחמד) for becoming wise, and she took from its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband.

Genesis 3:11 Instructor's Translation

God to Adam: "Who told you (מי הגיד לך) that you were naked?"

Genesis 3:13 Instructor's Translation

God to Eve: "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"

Jonah's Deception

Jonah 1:7 NASB

And each man said to his mate, "Come, let's cast lots so that we may find out on whose account this catastrophe has struck us." So they cast lots, and the lot fell on Jonah.

Jonah is selected by lot for his sin.

Jonah 1:8 Instructor's Translation

Sailors to Jonah: "Please tell us now (הגידה נא לנו)."

Sailors to Jonah: "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"

Achan's Deception in Joshua

Joshua 7:14-18 NASB

¹⁴ So in the morning you shall come forward by your tribes. And it shall be that the tribe which the LORD selects by lot shall come forward by families, and the family which the LORD selects shall come forward by

households, and the household which the LORD selects shall come forward man by man. ¹⁵ And it shall be that the one who is selected with the things designated for destruction shall be burned with fire, he and all that belongs to him, because he has violated the covenant of the LORD, and because he has committed a disgraceful thing in Israel.”

¹⁶ So Joshua got up early in the morning and brought Israel forward by tribes, and the tribe of Judah was selected. ¹⁷ So he brought the family of Judah forward, and he selected the family of the Zerahites; then he brought the family of the Zerahites forward man by man, and Zabdi was selected. ¹⁸ And he brought his household forward man by man; and Achan, son of Carmi, son of Zabdi, son of Zerah, from the tribe of Judah, was selected.

Achan is selected by lot for his sin.

Joshua 7:19 Instructor's Translation

Joshua to Achan: “Please tell me now (הגד נא לי) what have you done (מה עשית)?”

Joshua 7:21 NASB*

Achan: “I saw among the spoil a cloak of Shinar, a good one (טובה) and two hundred shekels ... and I desired them (ואחמדם) and I took them (ואקחם).”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah as the Scapegoat

There is only one other figure in the Hebrew Bible that has lots cast over them and is then “cast out” so that others may experience Yahweh’s blessing, and that is the scapegoat on the Day of Atonement in [Leviticus 16](#).

Jonah 1	Leviticus 16
1:7: And they cast lots, and the lot fell concerning Jonah.	16:8: And Aaron will give lots concerning the two goats, one lot for Yahweh, and one lot for going away (<i>azazel</i>). 16:10: And the goat which the lot went up concerning it for going away (<i>azazel</i>), it will stand alive before Yahweh for making atonement for it, by sending it for going away (<i>azazel</i>) into the wilderness.
1:14: “Please Yahweh, don’t let us perish for the life of this man, and don’t place innocent blood upon us!”	16:21a: And Aaron will rest his two hands upon the head of the living goat and will confess over it all of the iniquities of the sons of Israel.

Jonah as the Scapegoat. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah 1

1:12: “Take me up (נשא) and hurl me into the sea ...”

1:15: And they took up (נשא) Jonah, and they hurled him into the sea. And the sea stopped its wrath.

Leviticus 16

16:21b: And all their transgressions and all their sins, and he will place them on the head of the goat ... and the goat will take up (נשא) all their iniquities to a land of isolation, and he will send the goat into the wilderness.

Jonah as the Scapegoat. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Notice the personification of the sea as “wrathful” (Heb. *za’aph* / זעף), which is elsewhere used to describe Yahweh’s anger at humanity’s evil ([Mic. 7:9](#)) and likened to a storm.

Isaiah 30:30 Instructor's Translation

Yahweh will cause people to hear his voice of majesty, and he will display the descent of his arm, with wrathful (זעף) anger, and flame of devouring fire, and hail and storm clouds and rain and hail.

The Sailors as Ideal Israelites

In contrast to Jonah, who replays the deceptions of Eve and Achan, the sailors are portrayed as the humble and repentant Israelites from the structurally significant [Psalm 107](#).

Psalm 107 begins with an opening call for those who have returned from the exile to praise Yahweh for his covenant loyalty (Ps. [107:1-3](#)). This is followed by four mini-narratives that portray various acts of divine deliverance from chaos environments that are set in analogy to the Babylonian exile. They are arranged symmetrically.

A v. 4-9: Wanderers in the **desert** without food or water

B v. 10-16: **Prisoners** in the dark **because of their sins**

B’ v. 17-22: People with **illness** unto **death because of their sins**

A’ v. 23-32: Sailors on the **sea** threatened by a storm

In each episode, people cry out to Yahweh with the identical line: “And they cried out to Yahweh in their distress, and from their afflictions he delivered them” (v. 6, 13, 19, 28).

The fourth episode is the longest, and it portrays an iconic sea storm that threatens human wisdom and power that is represented by ships and their navigation.

Psalm 107:23-31	The Sailors in Jonah 1 and 2
Those who go down to the sea in ships who do business on great waters; they have seen the works of Yahweh, and his wonders in the deep.	1:3: And he went down to Joppa and found a ship going to Tarshish ... and he went down into it to go with them to Tarshish.
And he spoke and raised up a stormy wind , which lifted up the waves of the sea.	1:4: And Yahweh hurled a great wind onto the sea and it became a great storm .
They rose up to the heavens, they went down to the depths ; their soul melted away in calamity.	2:5: "Waters surrounded up to my neck , the deep encircled me ... I went down to the underworld."
They reeled and staggered like a drunken man, and all their wisdom was swallowed up .	1:17: And Yahweh appointed a great fish to swallow up Jonah.
Then they cried to Yahweh in their trouble, and he brought them out of their distress .	1:5: And they cried out each to his god. 1:14: And they called out to Yahweh. 2:2: "I called out to Yahweh from my distress ."
He caused the storm to be still, so that the waves of the sea were hushed.	1:15: And the sea stood from its raging.
Then they were glad because they were quiet , so he guided them to their desired haven.	1:11-12: "What may we do for you, so that the sea will become quiet ?"
Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love, and for his wonders to the sons of men!	1:16: And they offered sacrifices to Yahweh and they fulfilled their vows. 2:9: "And I will with a voice of thanks , I will sacrifice to you, what I have vowed I will repay."
The Iconic Threatening Sea Storm. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Both Jonah and the sailors are set in analogy with those rescued in Psalm 107, though Jonah undergoes an additional descent unto death from which he needs to be rescued.

Most significantly, the storm rescue in Psalm 107 is set in analogy with being lost in the wilderness, imprisoned, and sick unto death. Together these are metaphorical analogies to the Babylonian exile. This makes Jonah's story resonate with meta-themes of the Hebrew Bible: sin and rebellion among God's covenant people, a self-imposed exile away from the true temple in a search for a pseudo-Eden that draws one near to

chaos and death only to cry out and be rescued from the domain of death. All of these are brought into the orbit of exile and restoration themes, and Jonah's story now resonates with those larger biblical themes.

Jonah's Death Wish and Innocent Blood

Why does Jonah's solution to the problem involve placing blood-guilt on the sailors? Why doesn't Jonah cry out to Yahweh like the sailors did to their gods? Why is he making them "repent" on his behalf?

Is this a moment of noble self-sacrifice? Or is this another moment of Jonah's selfish lack of awareness? Would he rather die than try to save the lives of others, much less his own? The answers to these questions seems to lie in understanding the design patterns being activated by the hyperlinks in this scene.

The Suffering Prophetic Intercessor

Noble Moses

When Moses is at his best, he intercedes for idolatrous Israel when they least deserve it, even offering his own life in place of theirs.

Exodus 32:30-32 NASB

³⁰ On the next day Moses said to the people, "You yourselves have committed a great sin; and now I am going up to the LORD, perhaps I can make atonement for your sin." ³¹ Then Moses returned to the LORD, and said, "Alas, this people has committed a great sin, and they have made a god of gold for themselves. ³² But now, if you will, forgive their sin—and if not, please blot me out from your book which you have written!"

Not-So-Noble Moses

When Moses finally loses his patience, he inverts his self-sacrifice by asking God to kill him instead of having to lead these people.

Numbers 11:14-15 NASB

¹⁴ I alone am not able to carry all this people, because it is too burdensome for me. ¹⁵ So if you are going to deal thus with me, please kill me at once, if I have found favor in your sight, and do not let me see my evil.

Elijah's Death Wish

Once Elijah realized that he couldn't bring lasting change to Israel, he fled into pity-party mode and ran back to Mount Sinai where Israel's covenant with Yahweh began. However, instead of interceding for Israel and offering his own life in their place, he acts like not-so-noble Moses and asks God to take his life.

1 Kings 19:4 NASB

But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a juniper tree; and he requested his life, that he might die, and said, "It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life, for I am not

better than my fathers.”

The City of Bloodshed

Cain’s Murder, Sodom, Egypt, and Nineveh

Recall the design pattern activated in Jonah 1:2, where the city’s violence and oppression activates a network of biblical portraits of the city of blood.

Genesis 4:10 NASB*

The blood of your brother is crying out to me (אלי צעקים) from the ground.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain and Abel and Cain’s city of violence

Genesis 6:13 NASB*

The end of all flesh has come before me (לפני בא).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The generation of the flood

Genesis 18:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah, it is great and their sin is extremely heavy. ²¹ I will go down now and I will see if its outcry (צעקה) which has come to me (אלי הבאה) they have done, totally.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sodom and Gomorrah

Exodus 2:23 NASB*

And they cried out (זעק) and their outcry rose up to God (ותעל...אל אלהים) from their slavery.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Israelites in Egypt

Jonah 1:2 NASB*

For their evil has risen up before me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Nineveh

Israel’s City of Bloodshed

In Deuteronomy 21:1-9, Israel is given guidelines to prevent any of their towns from becoming like these cities of bloodshed. If a murdered corpse is found, there is a ritual for those who found it to be purified before God.

Deuteronomy 21:6-9 NASB*

⁶ All the elders of that city which is nearest to the slain body ... ⁷ and they shall answer and say, "Our hands did not shed this blood, nor did our eyes see it." ⁸ Provide atonement for people Israel whom you have redeemed, O LORD, and do not place innocent blood (אל תתן דם נקי) in the midst of your people Israel. And the bloodshed shall be atoned for them. ⁹ So you shall remove innocent blood from your midst, when you do what is right in the eyes of the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah and Jerusalem's Bloodshed

Jeremiah warns the leaders of Jerusalem that because they have shed the blood of the innocent, their city will come under God's judgment just as the cities of Cain, Sodom, Egypt, and Nineveh.

Jeremiah 26:12-15 NASB*

¹² Then Jeremiah spoke to all the officials and to all the people, saying, "The LORD sent me to prophesy against this temple and against this city all the words that you have heard. ¹³ Now therefore make good your ways and your deeds and listen to the voice of the LORD your God; and the LORD will relent concerning the evil he has spoken concerning you. ¹⁴ But as for me, behold, I am in your hands; do with me as is good and right in your sight. ¹⁵ Only know for certain that if you put me to death, you will place innocent blood (נקי דם נתנים אתם) on yourselves, and on this city and on its inhabitants; for truly the LORD has sent me to you to speak all these words in your hearing."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"Whereas Jeremiah in chapter 26 pleads for his life on the grounds that with his death, 'innocent blood' will be on the heads of the people of Jerusalem, it is not Jonah who tells this to the sailors, but the sailors themselves who pray to God, and thus remind Jonah of this danger. The two-way effect of this inversion is to diminish Jonah in comparison with Jeremiah and to elevate the moral sensitivities of the sailors. It also brings a fourth party into the picture, the citizens of Jerusalem in Jeremiah's day, their reaction to Jeremiah being contrasted to the Ninevites and their king ... Thus, Jeremiah is compared with Jonah in an inverted way."

Adapted from Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 102-103.

The Sailors Fear Responsibility for Jonah's Blood

The sailors cry out to Yahweh in fear that they might incur the blood-guilt of the prophet that rejected his mission to the city of blood-guilt.

Jonah 1:14 Instructor's Translation

“Please Yahweh, don’t let us perish on account of this man’s life, and don’t place innocent blood upon us (אל תתן ... דם נקיא), for you, Yahweh, have done just as you have purposed.”

These are the only three texts in the Hebrew Bible where the phrase “place innocent blood” (נתן + דם נקי) is used.

“The significant fact [in [Deuteronomy 21](#)] is that someone’s blood has been shed, and atonement must be made for the death by the symbolic killing of a calf ... the elders of the nearest town are not literally responsible for the murder, but they are in a sense ritually responsible, hence the rite of atonement. [This indirectly connects] with the situation of the sailors, who are concerned with the murder they are about to commit, to a man who is actually the guilty one (at least before God) ... In Jeremiah the ‘bad’ people wish to kill the ‘good’ prophet, and he pleads for his own life, not for his own sake, but because his death will bring the stain of ‘innocent blood’ upon Jerusalem. In contrast to both of these scenarios, Jonah, the ‘bad’ prophet, faced with the ‘good’ sailors asks that he be thrown overboard, and it is the sailors who try to prevent this act. Ironically, it is they, not the prophet, who are aware of the significance of shedding innocent blood and pray that God not hold this against them. The author of Jonah has synthesized the two texts, taking the context of Jeremiah while using the language of Deuteronomy.”

Adapted from Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah](#). Almond Press. 72-73.

Reflection Question

Are many people selected by casting lots in the Bible?